two days when the Chinese declared a unilateral ceasefire. It fell to him to pick up the pieces and rebuild the shattered defences along the border.

Then, the turn came for General Kaul to go. He had also had a distinguished military career and served as Chief of General Staff and General Officer Commanding in the northeast during the war. Sandhurst-trained and, like all the others, brought up in the British Army tradition, he had seen combat in Myanmar during World War II and in Kashmir in 1948. In the early 1950s, he had served with General Thimayya for the United Nations Neutral Repatriation Commission. He was closer to Nehru, though, and was seen as one of very few Indian Army officers who may have had political ambitions. But the war in the northeast was his downfall.

Kaul was at the frontline when the first skirmishes occurred along the border in mid-October, but fell ill from altitude sickness up in the mountains and had to be evacuated from the area and flown to Delhi for medical treatment. He was not able to return to the northeast until 29 October and his absence from the theatre of war was seen by his detractors as a sign of cowardice. He had developed ‘cold feet’, they said, and was ‘malingering’.[16] This was a highly unfair accusation, but given the political climate in India after the humiliating defeat that the Chinese had inflicted upon the Indian Army, he had no other choice but to bite the bullet and ask for an early retirement, which was duly accepted by the government on 11 December.[17]

Kaul was then only 50 years old. He eventually left the service, a bitter man, on 14 May 1963 and went on a year-long, personal tour of Europe, Japan, and the US. Had it not been for the blame he shouldered for the 1962 debacle, he would most probably have been looking forward to a future not only in the military but perhaps also in politics. The legendary American broadcaster Welles Hangen even saw him as a likely candidate to succeed Nehru as prime minister.[18]

There were also some unsung and largely anonymous victims of the war: India’s ethnic Chinese community. The authorities suspected that they were a ‘fifth column’ that had provided the Chinese military with information prior to the 1962 War and they were treated as traitors to the nation. It is beyond doubt that China’s Communist government had sent intelligence agents to India years before the 1962 War, but they were hardly to be found among India’s own ethnic Chinese communities. India’s